

The Story of an Hour

Kate Chopin · 1894

First published: Vogue, Dec 1894

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Gustave Caillebotte, Paris Street; Rainy Day (1877). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Story_of_an_Hour (revision 13961357), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Story of an Hour suggest about freedom and marriage?
- What does The Story of an Hour suggest about identity?
- What does The Story of an Hour suggest about irony of joy?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Story of an Hour	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*freedom and marriage* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Story of an Hour

Focus: a woman's brief taste of freedom

Content note (death, marriage as constraint): Sensitive content: Death; marriage as constraint. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death; marriage as constraint.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Told gently that her husband Brently has died in a railroad accident, Louise Mallard weeps, then alone in her room feels a growing, monstrous joy: 'Free, free, free!' She looks ahead to years that will belong to herself. Leaving the room, she sees Brently walk in the door, unharmed; he had not been on the train. She dies, and the doctors say of 'the joy that kills'.

Background: Published in Vogue in 1894, when married women's legal identity was still largely bound up in their husbands'.

Significance: Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes death; marriage as constraint.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are elusive, coursing, composedly, intelligent, repression. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name." In this sentence it means: hard to grasp, catch or put into words. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Story of an Hour would have known. Published in Vogue in 1894, when married women's legal identity was still largely bound up in their husbands'. Why does this story matter? Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to a woman's brief taste of freedom? I circle "intelligent", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength. But now there was a dull stare in her eyes, whose gaze was fixed away off yonder on one of those patches of blue sky. It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Imagery, Symbolism: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Story of an Hour develops the idea of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to freedom and marriage? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about a woman's brief taste of freedom, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes a woman's brief taste of freedom. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
elusive (adjective)	hard to grasp, catch or put into words	*She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
coursing (verb)	flowing quickly	*Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
composedly (adverb)	in a self-collected or self-possessed manner	*It was Brently Mallard who entered, a little travel-stained, composedly carrying his grip-sack and umbrella.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
intelligent (adjective)	having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree	*It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
repression (noun)	the holding back of feelings or desires	*She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
tumultuously (adverb)	in a wild, stormy, excited way	*Now her bosom rose and fell tumultuously.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
suspension (noun)	a pause in which something is held off or stopped	*It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
persistence (noun)	continuing firmly in spite of difficulty	*There would be no powerful will bending hers in that blind persistence with which men and women believe they have a right to impose a private will upon a fellow-creature.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
unwittingly (adverb)	without knowing or intending	*There was a feverish triumph in her eyes, and she carried herself unwittingly like a goddess of Victory.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
illumination (noun)	sudden understanding; a flash of insight	*A kind intention or a cruel intention made the act seem no less a crime as she looked upon it in that brief moment of illumination.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with freedom and marriage?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why is Mrs. Mallard told the news carefully? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She has heart trouble
2. Who first brings the news? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Her sister Josephine and Richards
3. What does she see from her window? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Signs of spring and new life
4. What word does she whisper? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Free
5. What do the doctors say killed her? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Heart disease, the joy that kills
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Story of an Hour” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Told gently that her husband Brently has died in a railroad accident, Louise Mallard weeps, then alone in her room feels a growing, monstrous joy: 'Free, free, free!' She looks ahead to years that will belong to herself. Leaving the room, she sees Brently walk in the door, unharmed; he had not been on the train. She dies, and the doctors say of 'the joy that kills'.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Story of an Hour”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Story of an Hour” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.” What does “elusive” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: elusive: hard to grasp, catch or put into words.
10. Reread: “Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.” What does “coursing” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: coursing: flowing quickly.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Story of an Hour” suggest about a woman's brief taste of freedom? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony.

2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the imagery in this story shape what we understand about a woman's brief taste of freedom? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
4. In the passage that begins “She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength.”, why might Chopin have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Story of an Hour”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Told gently that her husband Brently has died in a railroad accident, Louise Mallard weeps, then alone in her room feels a growing, monstrous joy: 'Free, free, free!' She looks ahead to years that will belong to herself. Leaving the room, she sees Brently walk in the door, unharmed; he had not been…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Story of an Hour” set up that the rest of The Story of an Hour will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What does freedom mean to you? Can you feel free and loved at the same time?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with freedom and marriage? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
10. Background: Published in Vogue in 1894, when married women's legal identity was still largely bound up in their husbands'. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Very widely anthologized; its last line is a famous case of dramatic irony.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Story of an Hour” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a woman's brief taste of freedom? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Story of an Hour”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to identity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Chopin need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Story of an Hour” treats a woman's brief taste of freedom with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Story of an Hour see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve freedom and marriage? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a woman's brief taste of freedom? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Kate Chopin about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz

1. Why is Mrs. Mallard told the news carefully?
   A. She has heart trouble
   B. She is deaf
   C. She is pregnant
   D. She is very young
2. Who first brings the news?
   A. Her sister Josephine and Richards
   B. The doctor
   C. A telegram boy
   D. Brently himself
3. What does she see from her window?
   A. Rain and fog

B. A funeral

C. Signs of spring and new life

D. A train

4. What word does she whisper?

A. Free

B. Gone

C. Lost

D. Alone

5. What do the doctors say killed her?

A. A fall

B. Poison

C. Grief

D. Heart disease, the joy that kills

6. In the line “She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.”, what does “elusive” most nearly mean?

A. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

B. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

C. flowing quickly

D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

7. In the line “Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.”, what does “coursing” most nearly mean?

A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

B. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

C. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

D. flowing quickly

Answer key: 1. A (She has heart trouble); 2. A (Her sister Josephine and Richards); 3. C (Signs of spring and new life); 4. A (Free); 5. D (Heart disease, the joy that kills); 6. A (hard to grasp, catch or put into words); 7. D (flowing quickly)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Story of an Hour,” how does Chopin show a woman's brief taste of freedom? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Story of an Hour, how does Chopin develop the idea of a woman's brief taste of freedom? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Story of an Hour develops the idea of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Story of an Hour (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Story of an Hour suggests about a woman's brief taste of freedom. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and imagery), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Kate Chopin uses irony in The Story of an Hour to complicate the reader's understanding of a woman's brief taste of freedom. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Story of an Hour within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a woman's brief taste of freedom responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Story of an Hour alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a woman's brief taste of freedom follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Story of an Hour and its treatment of a woman's brief taste of freedom. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and imagery, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Story of an Hour as evidence for a larger claim about a woman's brief taste of freedom in The Story of an Hour. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Story of an Hour as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a woman's brief

taste of freedom. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Story of an Hour.

SAT-style questions

1. *It was Brently Mallard who entered, a little travel-stained, composedly carrying his grip-sack and umbrella.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “composedly” most nearly mean?

   A. without knowing or intending

   B. sudden understanding; a flash of insight

   C. continuing firmly in spite of difficulty

   D. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner

2. *She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength. But now there was a dull stare in her eyes, whose gaze was fixed away off yonder on one of those patches of blue sky. It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Story of an Hour”?

   A. A woman's brief taste of freedom

   B. A family and a house collapsing together

   C. Endurance turning to justice

   D. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

SAT key: 1. D (in a self-collected or self-possessed manner); 2. A (A woman's brief taste of freedom)

Whole-book test

The Story of an Hour: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why is Mrs. Mallard told the news carefully?
   A. She has heart trouble
   B. She is deaf
   C. She is pregnant
   D. She is very young
2. Who first brings the news?
   A. Her sister Josephine and Richards
   B. The doctor
   C. A telegram boy
   D. Brently himself
3. What does she see from her window?
   A. Rain and fog
   B. A funeral
   C. Signs of spring and new life
   D. A train
4. What word does she whisper?
   A. Free
   B. Gone
   C. Lost
   D. Alone
5. What do the doctors say killed her?
   A. A fall
   B. Poison
   C. Grief
   D. Heart disease, the joy that kills
6. In the line “She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.”, what does “elusive” most nearly mean?
   A. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
   B. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
   C. flowing quickly
   D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree

7. In the line “Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.”, what does “coursing” most nearly mean?
   A. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
   B. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree
   C. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
   D. flowing quickly
8. As used in the story (“She did not know; it was too subtle and elusive to name.”), what does “elusive” mean?
   A. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
   B. the holding back of feelings or desires
   C. continuing firmly in spite of difficulty
   D. flowing quickly
9. As used in the story (“Her pulses beat fast, and the coursing blood warmed and relaxed every inch of her body.”), what does “coursing” mean?
   A. in a wild, stormy, excited way
   B. flowing quickly
   C. without knowing or intending
   D. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
10. As used in the story (“It was Brently Mallard who entered, a little travel-stained, composedly carrying his grip-sack and umbrella.”), what does “composedly” mean?
    A. a pause in which something is held off or stopped
    B. sudden understanding; a flash of insight
    C. in a self-collected or self-possessed manner
    D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree
11. As used in the story (“It was not a glance of reflection, but rather indicated a suspension of intelligent thought.”), what does “intelligent” mean?
    A. continuing firmly in spite of difficulty
    B. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
    C. the holding back of feelings or desires
    D. having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree
12. As used in the story (“She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength.”), what does “repression” mean?
    A. the holding back of feelings or desires
    B. without knowing or intending
    C. flowing quickly
    D. in a wild, stormy, excited way

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how freedom and marriage develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how identity develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

3. Explain how irony of joy develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (freedom and marriage, identity, irony of joy) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (She has heart trouble); 2. A (Her sister Josephine and Richards); 3. C (Signs of spring and new life); 4. A (Free); 5. D (Heart disease, the joy that kills); 6. A (hard to grasp, catch or put into words); 7. D (flowing quickly); 8. A (hard to grasp, catch or put into words); 9. B (flowing quickly); 10. C (in a self-collected or self-possessed manner); 11. D (having the capacity for thought and reason especially to a high degree); 12. A (the holding back of feelings or desires)

Essay assignments

Essay: Freedom and marriage

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Story of an Hour teaches about freedom and marriage. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops freedom and marriage across The Story of an Hour. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Story of an Hour (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of freedom and marriage. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in The Story of an Hour (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of freedom and marriage, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Story of an Hour's treatment of freedom and marriage in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour. Name your

critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on freedom and marriage in The Story of an Hour, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Identity

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Story of an Hour teaches about identity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops identity in The Story of an Hour. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops identity across The Story of an Hour. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Story of an Hour (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of identity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of identity in The Story of an Hour. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in The Story of an Hour (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of identity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Story of an Hour's treatment of identity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on identity in The Story of an Hour that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on identity in The Story of an Hour. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about identity in The Story of an Hour, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on identity in The Story of an Hour, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Irony of joy

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Story of an Hour teaches about irony of joy. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops irony of joy in The Story of an Hour. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops irony of joy across The Story of an Hour. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Story of an Hour (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of irony of joy. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of irony of joy in The Story of an Hour. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in The Story of an Hour (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of irony of joy, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Story of an Hour's treatment of irony of joy in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on irony of joy in The Story of an Hour that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on irony of joy in The Story of an Hour. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about irony of joy in The Story of an Hour, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on irony of joy in The Story of an Hour, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.